The Rite for the Dead

Mṛtyuvidhi · Toh 1260 · Derge Tengyur

གཤིན་གྱི་ཆོ་ག

The Rite for the Dead, known in Sanskrit as the Mṛtyuvidhi and in Tibetan as Gshin gyi cho ga, is a brief tantric funerary manual in the Hevajra tradition, describing the rite to be performed for a deceased person on each of the seventh-day observances after death. The practitioner, visualizing himself as his chosen deity, summons the consciousness of the dead person into a support such as a piece of their clothing or a paper bearing their name, purifies their karma and obscurations through light rays, empowerment with nectar and mantra recitation, and finally transfers their consciousness into the heart of the principal deity. Its colophon attributes it to the great master Kṛṣṇapāda and records that it was translated into Tibetan by the Śākya monk Nyima Gyaltsen Palsangpo at the temple of Tharpa Ling, after he had received it from an Indian paṇḍita. It is Toh 1260 in the Tengyur, where it belongs among the commentaries and ritual works on the tantras.

In the language of India: mṛtyu bidhi nāma. In the language of Tibet: The Rite for the Dead.

Homage to Hevajra.

When a person has died and passed on, and one wishes to perform the seventh-day rites according to the Hevajra tradition, one should make a support from some token of the deceased, such as clothing, or else write the name on a sheet of paper. The maṇḍala, the offerings and the torma should also be arranged according to the text.

Then, meditating on oneself as one's chosen deity, invite the wisdom maṇḍala, worship it with special offerings, and praise it with hymns of praise. Dedicate torma to the ḍākinīs and supplicate them for the desired aim.

Then, with light rays from the seed syllable at one's own heart, summon the mind of the one who has passed on, in the form of a short a, with a hook of light rays, and dissolve it into whatever support there is. Imagine it there as the body that was the fruition of karma. Light rays radiate from the seed syllable at one's own heart and dissolve into the heart of the one being accomplished, purifying all karma and afflictions, so that one imagines the body to be like crystal.

Then imagine that the wisdom maṇḍala together with the ḍākinīs, and the knowledge goddesses, confer empowerment with streams of nectar water from the vases they hold in their hands, and that by this washing all the habitual tendencies of the obscurations of the one being accomplished are purified.

Then do the mantra recitation. Imagine that from the syllable at your own heart a garland of the syllables to be recited circles like a coiled snake, and recite whatever garland mantra belongs to it. Light rays radiate from the mantra garland and dissolve into the heart of the one being accomplished; imagining that all the stains of the obscurations of body, speech and mind are purified, one should recite.

Then make aspirations, and turn it into a root of virtue. Then imagine that the consciousness of the one being accomplished, as a short a, is lifted up by a wind maṇḍala arising from yaṃ and dissolves into the heart of the principal deity abiding in the sky; this is the transference to a higher state.

If there is no support, imagine the body that was the fruition of that person's karma as though directly present, and perform the visualization as before. This should be done in this way on every seventh day.

The Rite for the Dead, composed by the great master Kṛṣṇapāda, is complete. Having listened well to it from the great paṇḍita Jinakarṇa, the translator, the Śākya monk Nyima Gyaltsen Palsangpo, translated it well at the great temple of glorious Tharpa Ling.

Translator's Notes

• The great paṇḍita's name is given in Tibetan as □□□□□□□□□□□□ ("Ear of the Victor"); it is rendered Jinakarṇa as the likely Sanskrit form, but the identification is uncertain. Some read the phrase not as a name but as "from the speech of the great paṇḍita." "Transference to a higher state" renders □□□□□□□□□, the sending of the consciousness of the deceased to a higher abode.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please

consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.